

Contemporary Challenges Faced By Pakistan

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The Statistical Escalation of Violence

2024-2025 Statistics

In 2024, Pakistan witnessed a 70% increase in terrorist attacks (521 incidents) with fatalities rising to 1,950. This surge reflects an intensification of violence rather than just numerical growth. The trajectory continued into 2025, with 300 attacks reported in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa alone during the first quarter. This density suggests militant groups are moving beyond hit-and-run tactics to establishing a persistent operational tempo.

The TTP and IS-K: A Dual-Front War

The Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) has emerged as the 'fastest-growing terrorist group' globally in lethality, recording a 90% increase in attributed deaths in 2024. Exploiting the strategic depth of the Afghan hinterland, the TTP has reorganized to launch sustained campaigns. Their focus has shifted from indiscriminate attacks to precision strikes against the security apparatus to demoralize police and military forces.

Simultaneously, the Islamic State-Khorasan (IS-K) has expanded its footprint. While TTP targets the 'hard' state (e.g., the Peshawar police mosque bombing, 95+ killed), IS-K targets 'soft' societal fault lines (e.g., the Bajaur JUI-F rally attack, 50+ killed). This division of labor creates a 'pincer movement' that stretches the state's counter-terrorism capacity to its breaking point.

Geographic Concentration

Violence is highly asymmetric, concentrated in the western border provinces which have effectively transformed into active conflict zones.

- **Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP):**
  KP saw a 69% increase in incidents in 2024, defined by direct engagements between militants and the military. Coordinated attacks on checkpoints, such as in Chitral (Sept 2023), have become frequent, indicating parts of the province are contesting effective state control.
- **Balochistan:**
  Balochistan registered an 84% upsurge in 2024, the sharpest deterioration. Violence is driven by a convergence of the ethno-nationalist Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) and Islamist militancy. Attacks on civilian gatherings, like the Mastung suicide bombing (60+ killed), hamper development initiatives including CPEC.
- **Other Provinces:**
  While KP and Balochistan bore the brunt, Punjab also experienced an 83% upsurge in terrorist violence in 2024, albeit from a much lower base. Conversely, Sindh recorded a 20% decline in incidents, the only province to show improvement

Hybrid Warfare

Hybrid warfare combines military and non-military strategies, information, cyberattacks, economy, and diplomacy to weaken an opponent without full-scale war. Pakistan faces these threats from both state and non-state actors.

Information & Psychological Warfare

The information domain is used to damage national unity and international image. Tactics include:

- Spreading fake news on social media to create confusion.
- Propaganda campaigns targeting the Armed Forces and nuclear programs.
- Promoting sectarian and ethnic hatred to divide society.

This directly targets public perception, morale, and Pakistan's global reputation.

Cyber Warfare

- Targeting Pakistan's financial stability by influencing global markets.
- Supporting anti-economic narratives to damage business confidence.

Economic Warfare

- Targeting financial stability by influencing global markets.
- Using advanced surveillance to monitor and slow down Pakistan's technological growth.

Tech Warfare

- Use of advanced surveillance to monitor Pakistan.
- Attempts to slow down Pakistan's technological growth.

Strategic Solutions

- **Strengthen Information Defense:** Create a national digital media monitoring system and penalize deliberate misinformation.
- **Improve Cybersecurity:** Establish a National Cyber Command and upgrade infrastructure.
- **Internal Stability:** Improve development in Balochistan and KP to reduce grievances.
- **Economic Resilience:** Expand CPEC and promote exports to reduce vulnerability.
- **Improve National Awareness:** Conduct public awareness campaigns on media literacy. Train government officials, journalists, and students in national security awarenes

Climate Change in Pakistan

Vulnerability Profile

1) Rising Temperatures

- Summers are getting hotter and lasting longer.
- Extremely high heat causes heatstroke, more electricity use (fans/AC), and weakens crop yields because plants suffer from heat stress.
- Cities get "urban heat islands" where built areas become much hotter than countryside.

2) Irregular Rainfall (Unpredictable Monsoons)

- Rain patterns are changing, sometimes heavy rain comes all at once, other times long dry spells happen.
- Farmers cannot predict planting time; crops may fail if rain is too late or too heavy.
- Sudden heavy rains also cause urban flooding because drains and roads are not ready.

3) Glacier Melting (Himalayan & Karakoram Ice Loss)

- Glaciers in northern Pakistan are shrinking faster.
- Short term: more meltwater increases river flows and flood risk.
- Long term: less glacier water means lower river flow in summer, causing water shortage for farming and cities.

4) Floods and Droughts (More Extremes)

- Pakistan faces both extreme floods (from heavy rains and glacier bursts) and droughts (long dry periods).
- Floods destroy homes, roads, and crops immediately.
- Droughts reduce drinking water and crop yields, hurting livelihoods over months or years.

5) Air Pollution (Adds to Climate Stress):

- Cities suffer from smoke, vehicle exhaust, and industrial emissions.
- Air pollution worsens respiratory illnesses and can increase heat effects (polluted air traps heat).
- Poor air quality also reduces life quality and productivity.

Effects

- **Agricultural Losses:** Crops face heat, too much or too little water, and pest outbreaks — yields fall and farmers lose income.
- **Water Shortage:** Less reliable rivers and reservoirs; groundwater drops in many regions; households and farms face scarcity.
- **Health Problems:** More heatstroke, dehydration, vector-borne diseases (e.g., dengue), and respiratory problems from pollution.
- **Economic Damage:** Repairing flood damage, replacing lost crops, and healthcare costs strain the economy and family budgets.

Climate Change in Pakistan

Challenges

- **Weak Infrastructure:** Flood defenses, drainage, and water systems are old or missing — unable to cope with extremes.
- **Limited Resources**:(Money & Technology): Government and local bodies often lack funds, skilled staff, or equipment to adapt effectively.
- **Lack of Public Awareness:** Many people do not know simple steps (water saving, heat safety), so risks are larger.
- **Rapid Population Growth:** More people need water, food, housing — increasing pressure on natural resources and services.
- **Poor Urban Planning:** Cities grow without green spaces or proper drainage; informal settlements are vulnerable to floods and heat.

Solutions

- Plant More Trees & Restore Forests: Trees cool cities, reduce erosion, and help store water. Community tree drives help quickly.
- Improve Water Management: Fix leaks, promote rainwater harvesting, small dams/ponds, and efficient irrigation (drip systems).
- Use Clean Energy: Solar, wind, and small hydro reduce pollution and dependence on expensive fossil fuels.
- Strengthen Early Warning & Disaster Response: Better weather forecasts, flood warnings, and prepared evacuation plans save lives and property.
- Increase Public Awareness & Education: Teach heat safety, water-saving habits, and local adaptation steps in schools and communities.

Roles

- **Government:** Make and enforce climate rules, fund adaptation projects, build resilient infrastructure, and support farmers.
- **Communities & Individuals:** Plant trees, save water, follow early warnings, and help neighbors during disasters.
- **Youth & Students:** Spread awareness, join local projects, and adopt eco-friendly habits (reduce, reuse, recycle).

Political Instability and Governance Crisis in Pakistan

Timeline of Instability

Phase 1: Foundational Instability (1947–1956):

- **Challenges:** Limited resources, lack of skilled personnel, refugee crises, no constitution.
- **Weak Leadership:** Frequent changes in Prime Ministers and Governor Generals.
- **Political Conflicts:** Divided political parties; 1949 Objective Resolution caused disagreements between Islamic and Democratic groups.

Phase 2: Constitutional Failure and First Military Coup (1956–1969):

- **1956 Constitution:** Pakistan became an Islamic Republic, but political problems continued.
- **1958 Military Coup:** General Ayub Khan removed President Iskander Mirza and took power.

Ayub Khan Era (1958–1969):

- **Achievements:** Economic growth, industrial development, Green Revolution, stronger foreign relations.
- **Problems:** Limited political freedom; East Pakistan felt neglected, leading to protests.
- **1962 Constitution:** Introduced a presidential system.
- **End of Era:** Ayub Khan transferred power to General Yahya Khan in 1969 due to opposition.

Phase 3: Tragedy and Rebuilding (1969–1988):

- Yahya Khan Era (1969–1971)
- Martial law continued; free elections held in 1970.
- Awami League won majority in East Pakistan, PPP won in West Pakistan.
- Power was not transferred, leading to protests, clashes, and military action.
- Result: East Pakistan became Bangladesh in 1971.

Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto Era (1972–1977):

- **Achievements:** Economic reforms, nationalization, foreign policy strengthening, 1973 Constitution.
- **Problems:** Opposition grew, private sector alienated, protests increased.
- **1977 Coup:** General Zia-ul-Haq imposed martial law, arrested Bhutto (later executed).

Zia-ul-Haq Era (1977–1988):

- **Policies:** Islamization, suppression of opposition, media control.
- **Economy:** Some stabilization due to Afghanistan war.
- **1985 Elections:** Non-party elections held.
- **1988:** Zia died in a plane crash, paving way for democracy.

Political Instability and Governance Crisis in Pakistan

Phase 4: Tumultuous Democratic Cycles (1988–1999):

Frequent conflicts between Prime Ministers, Presidents, and the Army.

Benazir Bhutto (1st Term 1988–1990):

- First Muslim woman PM.
- Conflicts with President Ghulam Ishaq Khan; weak economy and bureaucracy pressure.
- Dismissed in 1990.

Nawaz Sharif (1st Term 1990–1993):

- Privatization and Motorway projects.
- Conflicts with President and Army.
- Removed in 1993 along with the President.

Benazir Bhutto (2nd Term 1993–1996):

- Corruption allegations, law, and order issues.
- Dismissed in 1996 by President Farooq Leghari.

Nawaz Sharif (2nd Term 1997–1999)

- Nuclear tests conducted in 1998 reduced President's powers.
- Conflicts with Army and Kargil war tension.
- Removed in 1999 by General Pervez Musharraf.

Phase 5: Musharraf and Modern Era (1999–2025):

Musharraf Era (1999–2008):

- **Dual role:** President and Army Chief.
- **Achievements:** 2002 elections, media freedom, local government reforms, economic growth.
- **Problems:** Lal Masjid operation, judiciary crisis, 2007 emergency.
- **Resigned** in 2008 due to political pressure.

Modern Democratic Era (2008–2025):

- **2008 – PPP Government:** PMs Yousaf Raza Gillani & Raja Pervaiz Ashraf, President Asif Ali Zardari.
- **2013 – PML-N Government:** PMs Nawaz Sharif & Shahid Khaqan Abbasi, President Mamnoon Hussain.
- **2018 – PTI Government:** PM Imran Khan, President Arif Alvi.
- **2022 – Coalition Government:** PM Shehbaz Sharif; Imran Khan removed via Vote of No Confidence; economy collapsed.
- **2024–2025 – PML-N Government:** PM Shehbaz Sharif; new President elected; PML-N returned after elections.

Political Instability and Governance Crisis in Pakistan

Effects of Crisis of Governance in Pakistan

- Slow economic growth
- Poor education and health systems
- Rising corruption
- Lack of rules of law
- Public dissatisfaction and protests
- Weak democracy
- Poor global image of Pakistan

Causes of Crisis of Governance in Pakistan

- Unnecessary military interference in government matters
- Political leaders more interested in gaining and holding power.
- Corruption and misuse of public resources
- Frequent conflicts between military and civilian governments
- Weak democratic institutions and lack of accountability

Socio-Economic Inequality in Pakistan

In Pakistan, socio-economic inequality is visible in the unequal distribution of income, education, healthcare, and opportunities among different regions, genders, and social classes.

Main Aspects of Socio-Economic Inequality in Pakistan

1. Income Inequality:

- A small percentage of Pakistanis (industrialists, politicians, business owners) hold most wealth.
- Millions of people live below the poverty line, struggling for necessities like food, water, and electricity.
- Example: Urban elites in Karachi or Lahore earn millions, while rural farmers in Sindh or Balochistan earn very little.

2. Education Inequality:

- Private schools in urban areas provide high-quality education.
- Public schools, especially in rural areas, suffer from poor infrastructure, lack of teachers, and outdated curricula.
- Many children, especially girls, drop out due to poverty, child labor, or cultural barriers.

3. Health Inequality:

- Wealthy people go to private hospitals like Aga Khan or Shaukat Khanum.
- Poor people depend on government hospitals that often lack medicines, equipment, and specialists.
- Rural areas face extreme shortages of healthcare facilities.

4. Job Opportunities:

- Urban centers have more job opportunities in IT, banking, industry, and services.
- Rural areas depend on agriculture and informal jobs, which are low-paying and seasonal.

5. Living Conditions:

- Elite neighborhoods have clean water, electricity, and security.
- Slums in big cities and villages in remote areas face poor sanitation, unsafe housing, and lack of clean water.

6. Gender Inequality:

- Women have lower literacy rates and fewer job opportunities.
- Cultural norms in some areas restrict women's mobility and decision-making.
- Example: In rural Sindh or Balochistan, many girls are married young and cannot continue education.

7. Regional Inequality:

- Punjab and urban Sindh are more developed.
- Balochistan and northern rural areas have fewer schools, hospitals, and roads.
- This creates migration to cities, overcrowding, and pressure on urban services.

Socio-Economic Inequality in Pakistan

Causes of Inequality in Pakistan

- Unequal access to quality education.
- Concentration of wealth among elites.
- Poor government policies and corruption.
- Lack of industrialization and job opportunities in rural areas.
- Gender discrimination limits women's contribution.
- Political instability and weak governance.

Effects in Pakistan

- Extreme poverty rate: Millions live on less than $2 a day.
- Poor health and nutrition: Malnutrition and infant mortality are high in rural areas.
- Crime and unrest: Economic frustration leads to theft, gang violence, and protests.
- Slow economic growth: Inequality limits human capital and productivity.
- Social divisions: Tensions between rich and poor, urban vs rural, and different provinces.

Conclusion

In Pakistan, socio-economic inequality is a severe problem because wealth, education, healthcare, and jobs are not evenly distributed. Urban elites thrive while rural populations and women often struggle. Addressing these issues requires better governance, education reforms, healthcare access, and policies for fair wealth distribution.